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Josiah Gluck

Josiah Gluck is one of television's preeminent music engineers. During his 30-year gig at Saturday Night Live he has been responsible for the sound of a lengthy list of prominent artists and he received an Emmy award for "Outstanding Sound Mixing for a Variety Series or Special." Josiah has also produced and recorded music for GRP Records, and Steeplechase Records.

Josiah was interviewed via Zoom on July 13, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Josiah Gluck with me today. And I've been reading about you so I know what you do but I'd like to afford you the opportunity to explain it yourself. Because it's a bit complicated.

JG: Well it's kind of a unique straddling of both worlds in that I do music producing and engineering and I've had a lot of experience working in recording studios with different artists. But also I've spent thirty years at Saturday Night Live and I'm one of the two on-air music mixers for the show and I also handle post-production duties with other people where we take care of repeats, and I'm also sometimes mixing music videos that are produced for the show. So it encompasses a lot of audio production.

MR: So music and technology go hand-in-hand in your work. And I'm curious, when you were young which of those things seemed to attract you.

JG: You know I would have to say it was both things. I've always loved music and from the time I was I don't know five years old or so TVs, record players, movie projectors, all that sort of stuff just fascinated me and I always wanted to know how does this work, how does that happen, how do you deal with sirens going by? You know. I've just always loved that. And somehow this revealed itself to me I guess in college that you could combine these things. I mean I played around with tape recorders and trying to record stuff in high school but it was really working at a radio station in college that I got to do a lot of hands-on work with technology.

MR: And I'm going to assume dealing with dead air and things that go awry in a live situation?

JG: They can happen. Yes. I'm actually kind of surprised that they don't happen more often because there's so much at stake. We've had our share of mishaps whether or not it's during a sketch or something with music. That's also why we have dress rehearsals, to see where there could be a possible problem. But there have been failures on-air and you just roll with them. You just have to deal with it.

MR: Do you have in-house terms for certain things? I was thinking about today we have someone who's going to lip-sync although I know it's rare — I believe it's rare on Saturday Night Live but I'm just wondering if you developed a vocabulary with your teammates about things?

JG: No I mean you'll usually know whether or not someone is miming or lip-syncing, which is really not encouraged at all, and then sometimes we'll have — the one little bit of shorthand — I guess I shouldn't reveal this — is that someone will say, "Do you have microphone RF 15?" And it's like, "Yes I do." Or I'll say, "I have RF 15 on." And RF-15 is, we don't use a microphone named, Radio Microphone 15, it just lets them know somebody from the band is within listening distance or the control room and therefore be careful what you say on the PL. Be careful what you say.

MR: Yes sort of like a live mic somewhere.

JG: A live mic somewhere so they'll say, "These guys are idiots" it's like, "Oh, oh they must be talking about other idiots not you guys." You know so anyway. There goes the dog.

MR: That's okay. What's your relationship like with the house band? Is Lenny Pickett like a guy that you had this important relationship with over the years?

JG: Oh yes. I mean I've known Lenny for a very long time and parenthetically I wasn't working with Lenny at the time but right out of college the studio that I worked for starting in 1982 — no excuse me 1981 — one of our main clients was the SNL house band. And so some of these guys I've known, some of these cats I've known since 1981. The fall of 1981. But you know the band would come in and do rehearsals. No I mean I've worked with Lenny a lot and we'll always record the theme on a Saturday morning when the band is rehearsing just to be able to double check the mix and see if there's anything we want to change. There might be a sub in the band — it's rare — so you want to make sure that that's parked in properly.

MR: Do you have — of course you have the house band and then you have the live music guest. Do you have something in your head, in your hearing that matches them in the sense that overall volume, bass volume, all that kind of thing?

JG: Well you know I've always liked to say that on the spectrum of mixes like you can say well this is wrong and this is right, and everything else on either side of it is personal taste. But you want to hear the vocal. You want to hear the bass. To me a mix works when I'm hearing the bass and I can see and hear the drummer on the ride cymbal. I hear that whole spectrum. I see and hear the whole spectrum. So that to me is very important. As far as overall level, we're locked into certain broadcast standards of how loud you can be and then you're playing games with compression and apparent loudness and then there's also the questions of mixing in surround sound and do you do it in surround. We

because of where the vocal sits in the guest band mixes, how things fold down to stereo on YouTube or someone who's not watching on YouTube or that person who's standing next to me on the subway on Monday morning watching the show that way. So I also feel, I mean I love mixing in surround but I also feel that it affords the home user, sometimes 5.1, opportunities to completely wreck my mix. So you can only protect how well it sounds leaving you, leaving the studio.

MR: I'm glad you brought this up because it was sort of on my list. I've been thinking about how music — mostly in the pop world — the sound of it has changed so much over decades. And it came to — it's an odd coincidence because I was listening to, you know a Frank Sinatra tune from probably the late 50s and then on the way home there was this band called Fine Young Cannibals and they had this hit "You Drive Me Crazy."

JG: Yes.

MR: Right? And it had that backbeat like a Syn drum or something.

JG: Yes, yes. I know exactly what you're talking about. Yeah.

MR: Well that Syn drum was louder than anything. Louder than the vocal, and as an engineer I'm wondering does that pop out for you as something — or what am I trying to say — if you had been the engineer on that date would you have thought why — you want the thing that loud?

JG: I wouldn't have minded it and I think everything I've been doing over the years, any engineer, everything is a stylistic and aural learning curve. That is, that to me is — sonically it's a hook the way the chorus is a hook. One thing — I don't know why this one just pops in my head, there was a hit a number of years ago with Aaron Neville and Linda Ronstadt, "Don't Know Much." I am certainly not going to sing it, but their tight harmony to me is the hook, it's the signature of that song. So on the Fine Young Cannibals song that [scats] is very much a hook, the same way you listen to that very reverberant conga hit on "What's Going On," Marvin Gaye. That is also to me just a very — it's a sonic signature to that. Sinatra's music, you're talking about those great recordings done at Capitol Studios with their live chambers and so forth, to me that kind of engineering, and certainly jazz engineering and absolutely classical music, it's like taking dictation. You want to be as accurate and faithful as possible to what's happening. With certain pop music my feeling is that you can bend and mold the sound into — to serve the music, to serve the song, and also just the sounds that are now created are so much more varied.

MR: You've been a producer as well and I'm wondering if there's been occasions where you've been an engineer with another producer and because of your experience you think this is not the way to go that this producer is suggesting. And do you ever butt heads?

JG: No I don't think so. I mean I've been fortunate enough to work with some really fine people. I will say that I was working on a film score, "Good Shepherd" which was a film that Robert DeNiro directed and there was a little piece in the film where — I don't know if you've seen the movie but there's this Russian possible double agent, possible spy defector, whatnot, they ask him to play some violin. Just you're supposed to be this violinist, play something. And he was playing and we had this studio violinist just playing along, you know watching the film and doing it. And I had offered a suggestion to Mr. DeNiro about — because there was all these questions going back and forth about it and it was being played fine, and I just said maybe we should just bring the performance down a bit because it's very close, it's a one-on-one thing, we're not reaching the dress circle at Carnegie to make this happen. So Mr. DeNiro says, "What's your name?" And I'm like, "Uh Josiah." I mean would it be like I'm just the guy on the loading dock under a tarp, don't worry about me you know. But he got on the talkback and he said, "You know Josiah had an idea, why don't we try it this way?" And it worked. Now here's the thing. Tremendous gentleman by doing that and it was very touching but he also of course pre — sort of set it up so like well that didn't work — well it wasn't my idea this schmuck sitting here was the one who said it. You know. But it worked out very well and I spoke to him after the fact and he said, "No, you did the right thing, you weren't out of line." So, but those kind of things are so few and far between that I would offer that kind of thing to anybody. Because you sort of stay in your lane. But I have been doing this for a while. I'm not a composer, I'm not an arranger, but I have been doing this a while and you don't work in a vacuum and you work with a lot of different people and you get to be able to offer up constructive suggestions, I wouldn't call it criticism, when it happens. Also at SNL there is sometimes a great deal of hand holding with some people who are in for the first time and they're like, "Oh right, the mix," 'cause all they're worried about is how do I look? What does it look like? Because there are usually a lot of other creative people brought to bear on what that thing is.

MR: Are you aware or not if the band that the singers bring are usually their touring people? Or are they sort of picked for the show?

JG: It's almost always touring. If someone has let's say a bunch of horn players or they need a dozen strings then that will usually be a pick-up ensemble from the City. And you know, and in fact the music contractor we use, Sandy, who was the one playing violin in that thing, in that one story, I'll see her often at the show with that kind of — you know a contractor bringing people in.

MR: Just a personal aside I was happy to see a Hamilton alum from our college playing bass with Dua Lipa on Saturday Night Live. That was really cool.

JG: Yeah she's fun. She can sing, that's a fun band. This past season probably the highlight for me was working with Brandi Carlisle. She was just sublime. You know great voice, great songs, great players. And it was just playing. It was like no click-track, no tracks or whatnot. And I don't mean that in a dismissive way because you know playing back pre-recorded tracks or whatever sonic signature that has been created with loops and beats and editing and so forth you know from the get-go that is not something that is going to be necessarily replicated by people playing it. It's a sound created in the studio and so if you want to have the performance to be as close as possible or somewhat similar to what you do on record, then you have to bring that along. And everyone plays in lock-step to it.

MR: Do people use in-ear monitors on the show?

JG: Yes. A great deal. And that's been a huge help as far as cleaning up sound and making things tighter. You know I try to describe it to civilians as if you have a singer who's kind of singing away from the mic and they're not singing very loudly and they have a drummer behind them bashing away, it's going to get into that mic. And as I say imagine you were to take a perfectly still like tub of water and take flower petals and arrange the most beautiful mosaic design just floating on the surface and everything's working and all locked together. And then you pull the plug out the middle and everything just swirls and goes in and everything gets distorted because it all crashes into that one thing. And that to me is what happens when you have a lot of leakage that become an issue and half the battle with SNL is it's like a sonic house of cards. How to we get all these pieces to fit. And it can be done with all sorts of tricks of compression and EQ and side chaining and other things that studio people might feel like [gasps] you can't do that. You can't put that much on. It's like well how does it sound? Oh it actually sounds pretty good. Well then what does it matter? But it's a completely different discipline than being in the studio.

MR: Did you learn all this mostly on the job?

JG: A lot on the job. Well in college it was a nice linear progression because I went to Johns Hopkins as an art history and humanities major. Then I spent a lot of time at the radio station there and somewhere I could show you my GPAs so you could see just how much time I spent at the radio station. But I did do a little bit of class work at the Peabody Conservatory of Music which is now part of Hopkins but back then it was just this other place here in town. But they had a small recording set-up and the radio station — we got our blank tape from there and so forth. But most of what I've learned I've learned on the job. And so I've sort of come at it the other way where it's not a lot of theory and then some practice in a recording program. I've been in the trenches pretty much from the get-

go. And any sort of electronics or electrical engineering my background is still very limited with that, but I've learned by doing.

MR: Sounds like you have a future in the classroom someday.

JG: Well I do some courses, like master classes down at Peabody. I will bring down some SNL material and we'll play that and we'll talk about problems or listen to this leakage, listen to what we're doing here; and then there've been other times when we've brought in some local musicians and they all know it's kind of like these guys are going be actually watching us like this was an operating theater. But I'll work with the class and we'll set up and we'll record like a small fusion jazz ensemble and okay well let's try this, you want to put this bass here, drums there, okay, but you know there may be better issues as far — it may be better for the leakage but I'd rather work with the leakage and at least have the bass and the drummer be able to see each other. So to me it's all of that real world stuff. This is going to be such a digression but someone was once telling me about her dad frying a turkey. And she said what he does is he'll put the turkey in the empty big container, fill it with water, pull the turkey out and then measure the water, and then he knows that's how much oil to use. Because so many people fill the thing up, they put the turkey in and it spills over, it hits the fire and then fighter jets scramble because of the heat plume. You think something's launching. Now that kind of real-life common sense heads-up ball, that's how I love to approach what we do. And also don't lose sight of the music and don't lost sight of make it as comfortable and as easy for these people to make music. I never want to be in a studio situation where the pianist is like well yeah if I do this I can see the bass player. They shouldn't have to do that. And so which is why I'm always at sessions early making sure things are set up. The first thing, I'll sit at the piano and be like yeah well, I mean do you need to see the ocarina and zither player or not? It's all of this stuff. And that is what I don't know how much of that is taught. So when you said about the real world, you know, in a classroom situation, I like to talk about let's dress cables all in one direction around a drum kit and let's be careful how we set up our drum mics. You know if you have a mic stand here, you know you have a mic stand, well don't put the mic here, you bring things up and down like this so that no one walks around the far end and knocks things out of place. Well that was beaten, I'm sorry, drilled into me back in 1981 and it's all of that practical stuff which I think is just so key. And at that very first job, and I still remember this and I still talk about it and this is 40 years ago I guess, where I was told when you are an engineer you are one-third technician, one-third musician, one-third politician. And you have to be all those things at once to everybody. And it's just a huge help, and if you approach it that way — you know I like to make things easy-going. It doesn't mean I'm not paying attention and

MR: I'm so happy to hear you say that. I just did an interview not that long ago with a fellow named Hank Cicalo.

JG: Oh sure.

MR: He said, more than once, that his main goal was always to make the artist comfortable. And you are echoing that. And the thing you said about the mic stand I think is very apropos because I've learned if you're setting up in a tight situation to not have the end of the mic pole sticking out too far because someone's going to hit it and the mic is going to end up in your teeth.

JG: Yes.

MR: So your real-life experience is good.

JG: You know you might find this with a lot of engineers, I love to cook. And my kids like to cook. And I'm always teaching them all the little bits of shortcuts and how to do this and what to do and think things through because it just makes your job that much easier.

MR: By the way, do your kids know that you are a hip guy and have a cool job?

JG: They do to a degree. Yeah they do. I mean they've been up to SNL and hung out. I mean they're too young at 14 still to be in the audience, but they've hung out at the show, they've seen Daddy's control room, they've met some of the cast, they've met a couple of the guest stars who've been on and they like it. They're in camp right now and I just sent them a note, a little newsy note about oh the blah-blah-blah, this is going on with the dog, I did this and that, oh and yeah and by the way I got another Emmy nomination. So we'll see with that. They'll be like what!

MR: Yes and just so people know I requested that you put that Emmy behind you on the table and I'm very happy to hear about the second nomination.

JG: Thank you. Yeah it was a really interesting show, it was the one hosted by John Mulaney last season and as far as one of the things that happens at SNL the night before was when Russia invaded Ukraine. And so there was this last minute pivot to have this local Ukranian choir from New York City open the show. And I made a rather concerted effort to get it sounding right rather than just put like a mic on a stand here and here and whatnot. And I was able through my colleague Lawrence Manchester down at the Tonight Show get a hold of some really great microphones. They have these nice little Sennheiser mics and I put a little X-Y thing underneath the table looking up at this choir so you don't even see the mics, and then we had two mics and I'm using my camera here as this kind of thing (everything's backwards) to be able to put mics just out of range of the choir looking in so that we had four mics but you couldn't see them and it sounded lovely and then the big trick is to go when they say "Live from New York it's Saturday night" and you have to switch your snapshot to open up the house band and not have

those sort of things make it a little nuts. And then we had this band, LCD Sound System on which couldn't be more in the opposite direction of this choir, and we had a lot of other various complicated sketches with audio playback and singing and whatnot. So we all decided we would put this one in for consideration and lo and behold we got a nomination. So that news came yesterday and everyone texting back and forth, it's probably why the internet was kind of slow yesterday because everyone was just back and forth you know.

MR: I'm wondering if, you know Saturday night when the show was over, you know, "Okay we're off" if you and your colleagues sort of breathed this big sigh of relief?

JG: You do on some of them you do. I mean I've done an awful lot of shows there now over the years, you know either mixing or working alongside Jay Vicari who is the senior music mixer. So we — there's a lot under your belt but there's also a phrase that I heard which I really like, it's just tribal knowledge at this point. We've just done it a lot. And you know it's the same way with all the record work I used to do that you just become very comfortable in your style of working. You always have this great sense of accomplishment. For example I always like it when — I used to do a lot of work for Steeplechase Records, which is a small label out of Denmark. Now these were all live to two track jazz recordings. Great players. You'd do one or two takes, they'd come back in for a playback and someone would — you know a bass player would turn to the piano player and be like, "That thing you did in the chorus going out in the left hand, are you going to do that again because I'll try to stay out of your way" and do we want to do this and that and so forth, and nobody is saying anything about the sound or the mix. And at that point would it be nice for them to pick me up on a chair and throw rose petals? Sure. But the fact that no one is doing that means that you've got a vibe that's automatically helping the playing, the creativity, and you can just sort of recede into the background and I like that. I mean there'll be times when the guys are walking out it's like, "Everything okay?" "Oh yeah, sounds fine." You know.

MR: Yeah you're actually getting a compliment by the fact that they're not pointing something out, that this sounds good and so full speed ahead.

JG: My tired shtick at SNL is if some artist comes in, some performer comes in to listen to their playback and they'll say, "This sounds great, this sounds really nice." And I'll be like, "Look that attitu — oh you liked it, I'm sorry, never mind, never mind, it was something else never mind something else." But you know because it's a very difficult thing for them. I don't care if you're the first time you've ever been on the show or the tenth time you've performed on the show, to go from "Ladies and gentlemen" boom — and hit it live, is tough. Everybody has to be on their A plus game to make it happen. And

I know what the template is, I know what the stencil is every week. How that gets colored in I don't know until Wednesday evening when I get the email that says this is what the music department requirements are for sketches and pre-records," regardless of the theme, the closing theme, the bumpers, and the musical numbers, I don't know what else is going to be in. When I was thinking about the choir there was another night, it was after that, it was Christmastime it was after that school shooting in Connecticut, Sandy Hook. And we opened up with a children's choir singing "Silent Night." And we had Paul McCartney on that night and he did three tunes and one sketch got dropped between dress and air, otherwise there was live music from the moment we hit the air until we finished up. There was supposed to be live music in every sketch. I think there was even a little bit of music in Weekend Update. So those sort of shows are big exhales when you're done.

MR: Fascinating. In the recording projects you've done in the past and currently I'm wondering if you have a sort of a head — aural space that you prepare for depending on the gig. If you know you're going to be recording a fusion band and is your mindset different than if you're going to record a string quartet?

JG: I think, I would say yes and no in that by the very act of writing up an input list and knowing what microphones and where I'm going to place things and so forth, that's already in my, the forefront of my brain. I know what I want to achieve and this is how I have to achieve it. And I think if you were to talk to a lot of engineers as they're getting sounds together, as they're putting stuff together they're already thinking about the mix assuming it's not a direct to two-track which is what effectively SNL is. I mean you're mixing and you're getting the sounds, but you're balancing as you go. There's no, "Oh this needs to be a little louder here." Yeah. Let me go back and fix that. No. So you know it might be more I can — if it was a fusion gig and maybe a little straight ahead thing I might — I'll definitely approach how I record the drums differently, piano might be more open, more mics what have you, give you more choices. But I think everything is about going with what I know works for me and then possibly experimenting a little bit. But I don't think I necessarily — no I mean it's just this is the job, this is what I have to do, and these are the ways I do these jobs. If that makes any sense.

MR: Sure. Do you find that you enjoy or seek out silence when you're not working of course?

JG: Yes. I mean I do listen to music. I like to — well let's put it this way — I was recently, about a week or so ago we were up in Vermont for a week with just the dog and my wife. The kids are at camp. And it's just delightful up there. And we listened to music in the car but I don't think I was listening to much music when we were up in this little ski condo. It was just quiet and it was very nice. I like to joke that since I'm a native of New

all that oxygen being made is just deafening. But yeah, I mean I do seek out — I would say it's not a question of silence just less stimulation. And New York is quite the visual and aural and olfactory assault at times.

MR: Let me suggest two things that if they ever happen to you — what would be the first thing that would come to your mind? So your phone rings and someone asks would you live mix the New York Philharmonic in Central Park? What's the first thing that comes to your mind?

JG: Wow that's scary. I'd love to do it but it's a very big undertaking you know. And there are a fair number of people who will be in the audience, you know 150,000 people all figured it should be sounding somewhere — sounding differently. It would be, I suppose I'd like to try it. A tiny bit out of my wheelhouse but I would still like to try it.

MR: How about if you got a call to do a four month tour as a live mixer for Steely Dan?

JG: Oh well yeah. That — I'd be all over that. I'd have to talk to my buddy Coach [Michael Conner] who is their live front house guy. Yeah.

MR: You could switch chairs with him, put him on SNL.

JG: Yeah he'd be fine. We worked together when Paul Simon was through the show. Yeah that would be quite the challenge, that would be quite the amazing thing to do. You know and it's funny people, and I think rightly so, look at some of those Steely Dan records as just sort of the pinnacle, like the urrtex of how you create a pop record. But there are also just other — and the same way some people I would love to hear like these original multi-tracks from the Beatles stuff and so forth — well sure, who wouldn't? But then there are certain Motown songs, or certain classic California sound stuff like from The Association or things from The Spinners, some of that Philadelphia stuff. I would love to see what those multi-tracks sound like. Or some early Elton John or Jethro Tull, things like that. I'd just love to hear how that all sounds and get a sense of what those balances are. Because it's really about just finding space for everything in the mix and how it's just all going to sit. And I guess the other thing would be when those things were being recorded the assumption is — to hearken back to what I said earlier — is that they were thinking about the mix. But to know what the end mix sounds like now and to then hear the raw elements and think about wow how did they get there and how much is baked into the tracks. Because sometimes you would put a lot of reverb on and so forth. Now, if you don't need to commit to anything people just don't. Because everything is digital. That is all plug-ins if you're working in Pro Tools you add reverb after the fact, all of this stuff, but a lot of Beatles and a lot of other records of the day, certain reverb and echo delays and so forth were baked into the tracks. And you made those decisions then and there.

MR: Which means that when they recorded it the reverb was on. When you say baked into the track.

JG: Yeah that means it's recorded along with let's say the vocal and so forth.

MR: Right. I wanted to ask you about a few things that are in your bio.

JG: Okay.

MR: Name this tune: [scats "Theme from St. Elsewhere"]

JG: Oh yes. St. Elsewhere, yeah working with Dave [Grusin] on the St. Elsewhere theme. That was — I had just started at GRP when that happened. And it was just all layered up with synthesizers. There was a long, long day and bringing in this outside synchronizer and this 3/4 inch pneumatic and linking it up to this deck. I mean it seemed all very Steampunk-Rube Goldberg compared to now, where you just would be doing it on Pro Tools and you would have an embedded video file and streamers and everything else that you needed to make it happen. So yeah that was fun. And then I remember I got the call from them and I dusted off the multi-track, took it off the shelf and re-mixed it for a stereo when the show started doing stereo broadcasts I guess in 1985.

MR: Was there any acoustic instruments on that recording?

JG: A triangle.

MR: I know exactly what you're talking about, right in the middle. Ting.

JG: Yeah that was Dave playing triangle in this little closet vocal booth we had.

MR: I love those kind of stories. You did — actually there's a name on your list of a fellow who is very important to our project here, Joe Williams. And he was on that "Happy Anniversary Charlie Brown" record.

JG: Yes. That was recorded in many different places and I didn't work on Joe with his track.

MR: Okay.

JG: I did B.B. King I think and Patti Austin and then I mixed some other things that came in. I'd have to literally look at the credits to figure it out. But I don't — no I didn't do Joe's thing.

MR: Were you on the "Night Music" series with David Sanborn when Sun Ra was there?

JG: No I only did the first half of the first season.

MR: Was that — that was not live was it?

JG: No it was recorded but there was a big cross pollination between that and Saturday Night Live at the time. A lot of people from that show worked there. My boss, my late boss at SNL, Stacey Foster, had hired me to do "Night Music" when effectively he had no business doing so. Because I hadn't had a lot of live experience other than doing a live record with the flutist Dave Valentin at the Blue Note a few months before. It's like well okay I guess I've done something live now. But they were putting the show together and

and David, and yeah I did part of the first season based upon my work at GRP I was brought in. That's how I was hired. And that was the transition when I went freelance away from GRP and started working out freelance, even though I continued to do a bunch of work for GRP for about a year. It was as though I never left, I just wasn't a full time employee there. And keeping in touch with the people from "Night Music" is how I ultimately got the call for SNL. And I spent the first three years at SNL doing audiotape playback, music stings, building all the underscore that Hal Wilner, may he rest in peace, picked up. Put all that stuff together. And then I had the opportunity to move into the music mix room, which was really my forte and got — moved along through there. And I'll tell you that I spent ten years in that music room — quite honestly — before I was even permitted to run a show myself. And can I tell you I was more than happy to wait that time. Because there is so much at stake, there is so much to learn, there's — and I had done all of these jazz albums working with Dave and doing this fusion stuff, and I had, by the time I got to SNL I had done ten years in the studio and a couple of Grammy nominations for engineering under my belt. But I hadn't done major rock acts and heavy duty pop work live on television. And so that to me was a big learning curve and I was very happy to ride the curve all the way to the top.

MR: I assume that you've taken a razor blade to tape a number of times?

JG: I have. I remember doing a project with Dr. Billy Taylor and the Turtle Island String Quartet and it was 24-track analog, one of the last projects I guess I did on 24-track analog. And he was doing some sort of I guess best could be called a cadenza and it came down and there was this downbeat and then we were going to cut to something else. And you know sometimes when you rock tape you can hear what you need to do rather easily. And there was one thing, I don't know, and I even — the tape was rolling and just at the spot I just tapped the tape as it was going just to see if I could then hear and see where I thought the spot was. Tapped it with a grease pencil. And it was like all right, you know, I made the cut, put it together, and it played back and we were like, "Wait, let's play that again." I played it again and Dr. Taylor just turned to me with his big glasses and he went, "That shouldn't have worked." But it did you know. But I used to love that sort of stuff. I was fearless about editing tape.

MR: I remember the first time I saw it happen I was astounded actually. And then to learn that it happens in classical performances also, I guess I didn't envision that it would even be used in the classical world.

JG: Very much so. I mean the same way there back in the day there were these very special splicing blocks. And usually you'd have like a sort of an angle like this, maybe an angle a little more. But some of them had very long angles so you could do a very smooth cross

could just — well I'm going to make this happen here, I'm going to make that there, I'm going to actually make the drums the overheads if I was cutting something with the drums I want the downbeat here but I will just smooth this out a bit so the cymbals don't exactly happen at that point, and it just — I mean you can play with it forever. But those sort of things are terrific. As I like to say it's Pro Tools not Pro Crutch you know? You have to — you can't go in there and fix every little thing because then you take all the life out of it. It's the same thing with auto — with people tuning stuff up. Well that's kind of nice. That's a little blue note in there, you might as well leave that, but then if you fix this note well then all these others start to feel out as well. Everything in relation — what — and then it just becomes a judgement call and I don't know how to describe it, it's just that what are we making here guys, are we making a record? Are we capturing this thing? It's the same thing with people — "Oh I want to fix this part, I want to fix this, fix that." I said, "You know what we could also do, we spend an hour and a half with everybody coming with all the fixes they want to do and punching things in and out, or we could take another 4 minutes and 17 seconds out of our lives and try another take and maybe that one will work really well, or there may be an element from the previous take we want to drop in." But just because you can do all of this stuff doesn't mean you necessarily should do it.

MR: Words of wisdom. I remember a phrase that — in the studio work I was able to do, this, "We'll fix it in the mix." And I said after that's said ten times I'm envisioning this mix from hell.

JG: Yes. I remember a buddy who would be like, he just walked into the studio like, "Well you can fix it in the mix. Oh — this is the mix? Jeez I'm sorry." You know. It's like — because at SNL just the culture of chops being busted sometimes is just relentless. Like, "Oh so you want it to sound like that. Okay." You know. I mean but that's just the nature of it. But that also happens on sessions and in situation where everybody is just really good at what they do.

MR: I had this — I was listening to a symphony, a Beethoven symphony the other day and the balance of the instrumentation. I wonder if you've had the experience of recording an orchestra and then sitting with the conductor who has been responsible for the sound of the orchestra but now he wants to hear more violas. Is that even possible in that setting?

JG: It can be, depending on what kind of forest of microphones you have put up, but typically orchestras should be recorded with as few microphones as possible. Film score recording has a much bigger forest of microphones because you may want to pick things out to help you in and around dialogue and exploding planets and spaceships or what have you. But if something is done in a very bare bones, traditional manner, what they call the Decca

outriggers further out. "You want more violas, Maestro? Might I suggest at bar whatever they dig in a little more. Because this microphone array is designed to pick up where all the sound is coming to one spot. Typically it's like a tripod of mics up above the conductor. I think it's supposed to be like 10-1/2 feet above his head or something like that, and all the sound is arriving there which is how you want to experience that. So if he wants to hear more he's got to dig in or she has to tell them, "Moose call, ocarina, zither at bar 75, play louder."

MR: You must like ocarinas, that's the second time that's come up.

JG: I know well you know it's a funny instrument, it's a funny word, it's got the hard k sound you know, comedy. What can I tell you? But yeah I like to think that the technology and the music are — it should be a collaboration and a cooperation of how you're getting this done, which is the same way I've always felt that the phrase when they talk about so-and-so you know Intergalactic Records recording artist and so forth, yes, because there is an art to making a recording. And there are some people who are great players, they're not necessarily great performers, but there is an art to making a recording and knowing how to use the studio and help put things forward. And one of the things I've talked about at Peabody and a couple of other things is you know all of this gear you can put up on a bench, on a test bench, and prove in a very precise manner how well it does its job: frequency response, rise time of this, phase lock of that, all of these things you can really measure how precisely it works. But we use it to capture and manipulate, re-convey that art form which to me is the most personal in that we can all look at a Picasso or a Renoir or a Michelangelo and say, "Well this is blue, this is green, this is this form, this is that form. But music is that sort of thing that affects all of us very personally, very deeply. This is the way I feel about it. And you know I like something that you like — seriously? And vice versa. And so you take that very personal, very almost intimate way you experience it and yet you have to use all of this precise technology to capture it and then re-convey it. And I just think that that's a very interesting marriage of two things. It's — you know I like to say that theory and my Metrocard will get me on the subway but nonetheless it's just an interesting way of looking at it and so forth. And the most successful recordings to me are the ones, and I always look at some of The Beatles and other things, where just somehow all of the technology just sort of recedes into the background and all you are left with is the music. That you're not aware of things. Like certain film directors have that kind of where they're right in your face, "Oh look at me, I'm being directed. I'm directing the movie." And I feel certain record producers can be, "Look at me I'm producing." But the things that just sort of leave you with the experience of the music and the sound and everything serves it and nothing is overly

flashy or distracting. Those to me are the — and how do you really define it? It's like well it's a mystery. But I mean it's the sort of thing when things work you just know it.

MR: That makes me think what you said about 15 minutes ago when the musicians came in and they didn't tell you they needed more of this or more of that, sort of that thing you've achieved, recording karma or something.

JG: Well it's like when I said earlier about you know this is that and then this is personal taste on either side you know. It's a question of if your taste and your sensibilities match what other people like. But also if you listen to certain records — yeah if I'm doing a little jazz trio or quartet or something with a singer, that kind of, that music, that genre kind of dictates how the mix's already going to be. You kind of have a starting point which is half the history of recorded sound. But if you're doing like the Fine Young Cannibals that you mentioned, that's new, that's different, and I think it's a question of what can we get away with and what can we make ourselves — how you make things stand out. I mean don't forget that thing, if it's playing on the Muzak somewhere kind of at low level, you'll still hear that. You'll know what that is instantly. So that sonic branding is I think as equally as important as taking the dictation and being true to the music. And yeah there are times at SNL where things are really out there and things which are much more traditional. And there are certain bands where there are very complex things where all these different synths or people coming in with a big band like an Arcade Fire or something like that, I welcome the direction because, or if someone says, "Well I need this little echo move right here and this verb thing." I'll be like, "Guess what? This is your fader, it's live TV, you're out with these guys 739 nights a year, you know where this move is, this is your fader, good-bye and good luck. You do it." It also gets them involved in it and so forth and because there are certain people who'll just be sit there don't even look at my console, don't touch my console and all of that. And I don't know I just don't understand any reason why you would do that. It just makes no sense to me why you wouldn't want the help.

MR: Is there anything that you miss, a bygone technology, the tape or those massive plate reverbs or something like that?

JG: I just — what I miss is that a lot of the nice studio spaces here in New York and also in general have all gone away. The need for that and having all of these musicians play together is few and far between. That is I used to do a bunch of work for Air Force bands and go to different studios. I went to a studio in Anchorage, Alaska to record different bands and Anchorage in the middle of January is a real garden spot let me tell ya. And I did work in Dallas and in Omaha with these bands. And to first of all go in and do that and set things up and you know you walk into a studio and it's like well let's see you've

sharpener, yeah I think we can do this. These are the tools, let's do it. And I love that challenge of going into a new room, new for me, and making that happen. And you don't often have the opportunity when there's an 18-piece big band and you've, "Yeah let me hear a little bit of this and that" and you just have the sections play a little bit just to make sure that they're all fine with ears and whatnot, and then it's like, "Okay well let's try one." And someone counts it off and like at the end of four you're just like, "Mommy!" because you don't know what's going to hit you. And then just that roar of sound of everyone playing together is just fantastic. You get that now at SNL if I get a good band and they start playing the first thing down when it's just all coming together is great. That's another thing, when you're doing SNL and we have monitors for everyone in the band whether or not it's in-ears or wedges and PA, it has to happen for the studio audience. That's when the drums can be a little tedious. Like let's hear the kick drum. Okay let me hear the next thing. You know? But if I'm in a studio I'll make friends with the drummer by putting the mics where I want them. I'll say, first of all, "Is anything in your way? Are you going to hit anything?" "No it all looks fine." I said, "Okay." That 20-minute solo they're not going to let you put on the record, I'll listen to it now thank you, and just start playing and I'll just start molding and getting in there and doing what I need and deciding yes I do have that mic but I don't think I need it. Always listen to the overheads first to hear whether or not someone is going, you know, snare-hat-tom tom tom-snare-hat. Or they're playing a unified kit. And that will become readily apparent, especially if you're using like a coincident pair of things. And you know as I used to say, and the same thing with mixing, how do you carve an elephant out of a block of marble? You just chip away everything that doesn't look like the elephant. So for me with the mix it's just slowly molding things into place. Tucking this in, pulling this out a bit, making this fit next to this better. It's all a very — it's very tactile and it's also very subtractive as in why don't I hear — well I'll throw this in for you — why don't I hear the ocarina? Or maybe something's in the way, or I actually need more of it. But if you can't hear something, if you start, "Well I need more this, more this, and all of a sudden all your faders are up to the wood and you have nowhere to go. Mixing to me is very subtractive. See what's in the way of something first, whether or not it's a frequency thing, whether or not it's a level thing. It could even be a placement thing within the stereo field. And all of a sudden this opens up and this becomes a little easier to hear. I mean this is all because I've been doing this for a while, it's not that — you know the deep fried turkey thing, you've watched one too many people put the turkey in, and you go to yourself, "I'm not doing that." So you begin to learn from your own mistakes, disasters, what have you. I've done things on SNL where it's just — and even in the studio — where it's just

out of the way of the vocalist. Just work with the level. I don't want to do anything to the innate dynamics of the vocalist. They've got that. But if I feel from where I'm sitting that the pianist is maybe digging in a little bit too much and I'm losing the vocal I would sooner pull the piano back just a dB or something so that the vocal, there's never any percept slight change, however imperceptive of what that vocalist is doing. Again, it works for me. It's just a methodology that I've developed and —

MR: It made me think of some of the mixes — I didn't think of it at the time — a band with a vocalist and the engineer would spend hours on getting all the levels and the sounds and the placement in the stereo field with all the instruments and they'd get this wonderful sounding thing but the vocal wasn't there yet. And then lastly we'll put the vocal in. And when I think back on it well there's no room left now for the vocal. I don't know if it's ever done backwards, put the vocal up and form the sound around that.

JG: Some people work that way. I kind of do both at the same time. What I'm usually listening for, and whether or not it's with a little bit of echo or a little bit of delay, you know some people mix where it's the band is like the straight line and then the vocalist is out front. But I try to create like a little cushion. Imagine like a little sort of pillow. I don't know how to describe it, like that, and then the vocalist rests here. So the band sort of comes around them and you achieve that with a little bit of reverb or echo. I also find it's not so much when I'm doing the television work because you're always watching it and looking at it will also change your perception of how the mix feels. But if I'm doing any number of vocalists I've worked with like let's say someone like Nnenna Freelon, who is this fabulous singer, I'm playing back a mix and I'll just sort of sit there with my eyes closed just like this. And it's not like I'm going to fall asleep or drool on the faders or anything, but you just sort of really get into it. And then if something's out of place — oh wait what's that? What's that? Then I'll hear it and I'll be able to say let me go back and hear what pulled me out of this space for a minute. What pulled me out? What was out of place for me? And then I can adjust that. And I remember years and years ago I grew up in a very large sprawling apartment in Manhattan and my parents would typically have, you know, cocktail parties with their colleagues. They were both college professors. And there'd be 75 people milling about and so forth. And I'd be talking to someone and the doorbell would ring. I'd go, "Oh let me go grab the door." They're like, "How did you hear that?" It's like, "Your hearing must be so tuned in, it must be so good." I said, "No what my hearing is, something was out of place. Something caught my ear, rather than I'm like this bat always listening for stuff." It's like here's the noise floor, the murmur of people and then, doorbell. Just that intruded for one second. And I think that stuff's just training, that's experience, it's time served.

MR: Well you speak very eloquently about your craft and art. And I appreciate your time. I think this is a really valuable session for musicians and potential engineers. And I want to thank you for your time and I hope that you land that second Emmy.

JG: Emmy. Fine. Thank you. I'm looking at three Emmy nominations here. Those have always been bridesmaids, never a bride. But we'll see what happens. There's always time to do that. Thank you so much for the invite to do this, it was really wonderful. Thank you.

MR: Well thank you and I'll pause here and we'll say our good-byes.

JG: Sure.

MR: Best wishes to you for your future career.

JG: Thank you, and with everything else you're doing.

MR: All right.